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REVIEW ESSAY

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A prism of the educational utopia: the East Asian Educational Model, reference society, and reciprocal learning

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ABSTRACT

This paper discusses the emergence of the new global educational governance characterized by 1) global educational reform movement, 2) the active participation of the international organizations in global educational policy making, and 3) the emerging performative culture. Against this background, this article contextualizes the East Asian Educational Model (Shanghai, Singapore, and Hong Kong) and its operation mechanism by appropriating the Confucian habitus and educational harmonization. Then this study compares the EAEM, the high performing educational system, and the representative global fourth-way countries by interrogating the underling binary—new orientalism vs. reciprocal learning. Finally, this paper draws some implications by learning from these different educational systems.

KEYWORDS

East Asian Educational Model; reference society; reciprocal learning; high-performing education systems; Confucius habitus; new orientalism

Introduction

The monograph *Comparing high-performing education systems: Understanding Singapore, Shanghai, and Hong Kong* systematically probes into the educational structures, underpinning ideologies, dominant policies, and representative practices in the three aforementioned jurisdictions. These three localities have consistently performed well in international large-scale assessments (ILSA), such as the Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) and Teaching and Learning International Survey (TALIS), in recent years. This book provides a fine-grained comparative analysis of these three educational systems in a timely manner. As a prolific scholar on education, the author Charlene Tan adroitly integrates eastern and western analytical frameworks in this book. She further posited that Singapore, Shanghai, and Hong Kong exemplify an East Asian Educational Model (EAEM), which contributes to an alternative Confucian understanding of the high-performing education systems (HPES) in this globalized world.

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The emergence of the new global educational governance

At the beginning of this review essay, it is necessary to sketch out three aspects of the contextual background in which this study was undertaken: (1) the global educational reform movement (GERM); (2) the active participation of international organizations in global educational policy making; and (3) the emerging performativity culture. In this way, the potential readers might better understand why we should care about the emergence of global educational governance and the focus on ILSAs and HPES.

To cater to the needs of the knowledge economy and twenty-first century competencies (Dale, 2005), many countries worldwide intermittently initiate waves of educational reforms (Hargreaves & Shirley, 2012), which are mainly underpinned by neo-liberal ideology (Hanushek, 2013). The GERM is mainly driven by extrinsic factors, such as maximization of human resources and fostering global economic competitiveness. The Finnish educational researcher (aka the Finnish 'educational ambassador') Sahlberg (2011) posited that the current GERM has the following distinguishable features: standardizing teaching and learning, increased focus on literacy and numeracy, teaching for predetermined results, the transfer of innovation from corporate to the educational world, test-based accountability policies for schools, and increased control of schools. Within the niche of GERM, teaching has become a technical and linear process that strives for measurable outcomes (Biesta, 2009). Simultaneously, teachers' working environments have become more bureaucratic and regulated with less autonomy (Sahlberg, 2011). To date, the GERM is still ongoing in many countries, such as the USA, UK, Australia, and China.

Second, international organizations are active participants in global educational policy-making. In recent decades, some international organizations, particularly the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD), have been become influential educational policy actors by the means of PISA and TALIS (Johansson, 2016; Sellar & Lingard, 2014; Tan, 2019a; Wiseman & Taylor, 2017). Through a series of PISA-based test products that aims to measure individuals' different competencies, OECD has strengthened its role in global educational governance by expanding its global policy network (Gulson et al., 2017; Wiseman & Taylor, 2017). The OECD has fostered the global mobilization of 'policy referencing', 'policy borrowing', and 'best practice' (Burdett & O'Donnell, 2016; Tan, 2016a, 2016b; Tan & Chua, 2015). For instance, Tan (2016a, 2016b) revealed that, to redress its deep-rooted teacher-centered pedagogy, China borrowed inquiry-based learning and constructivism-oriented instruction from the West amid the New Curriculum reform in 2001 (Fu, 2018; Tan & Chua, 2015; Tan & Reyes, 2016). More recently, Shanghai has borrowed the neoliberal knowledge, techniques, and logics in the New High-Quality School project, which persuades parents in Shanghai to opt-in to non-elite schools rather than prestigious schools that excel in academic outcomes (Tan, 2019b, 2020).

Third, there is a performativity culture in many schools. As Ball (2003) states, performativity is 'a technology, a culture, and a mode of regulations that employs judgments, comparison, and displays as means of incentive, control, attrition and change – based on rewards and sanctions (both material and symbolic)' (p. 216). In its fundamental sense, performativity can be understood as the top-down demands on schools and teachers to 'perform' and 'produce' some desirable outcomes according to the pre-determined policy regulation (Priestley, Biesta, & Robinson, 2015; Unterhalter, 2017). Within the

performative society, teachers and students' knowledge become commodified (Ball, 2012), and their respective performances are governed by numbers (Ball, 2015; Sellar, 2015) – a broad array of measurement and indicators.

Currently, there are three mains strands of performativity in schools: (1) the audit/target culture, which focuses on the improvement and quality of education through statistical data (e.g. examination statistics); (2) interventionist regulatory mechanisms, particularly school inspections, which includes self-evaluation and externally defined performance indicators; and (3) a market environment, where parental choice is facilitated by publicly available data from inspections and attainment statistics (Wilkins, 2011; cited by Priestley et al., 2015). Some illustrative examples of performativity include merit-based pay and value-added evaluation, which involves monitoring teachers' performance based on some designated rubrics. However, the performativity culture sometimes inhibits teachers' agency and threatens their morale, which inevitably undermines teachers' autonomy (Biesta, 2015).

What is the East Asian Educational Model (EAEM)?

According to ILSA results, particularly results from PISA, Singapore, Shanghai, and Hong Kong are all constituents of HPES (Waldow, 2017; Zhu & Deng, 2019). Meanwhile, scholars and international educational consultancies have published a series of books, articles, and signature reports on these three localities (Darling-Hammond & Lieberman, 2012; Darling-Hammond & Rothman, 2015; Hargreaves & Shirley, 2012; Sellar & Lingard, 2013). However, when they analyze the contributing factors to the HPES, most of them adopt a culture neutral stance – they rarely take the explicit or implicit cultural norms governing these bodies of educational jurisdictions seriously. For instance, while analyzing mathematics teaching in Germany, Japan, and the USA, Stigler and Hiebert (1999) found that teaching is a cultural activity, which intimately involves the underlying cultural script, which embodies a series of tacit, commonly-shared cultural beliefs among groups of people. This cultural script (un)consciously influences educational practitioners and policy-makers' logics of knowing, doing, and becoming.

Against the backdrop of Confucianism, Tan (2015, 2016b) identified five longstanding dominant cultural scripts for education in China: (1) the premium placed by many Chinese on education; (2) the focus on knowledge production, textual transmission, and didacticism; (3) high-respect for teachers; (4) strong foundational knowledge based on systematic learning, memorization and repeated practice; and (5) affective abilities and motivation. Currently, these five cultural scripts are still prevalent in Chinese education and the Great China region, such as Taiwan, Hong Kong, and Macau (Bray & Qin, 2001; Lo, 2016). Further, these cultural scripts collectively constitute the Confucian Heritage Culture (CHC). According to Tan (2018), CHC exhibits the following features: the importance of education; the high expectation for students to achieve; an exam culture; an emphasis on personal effort; the use of repeated practice and memorization; and the virtue of modesty (Tan, 2018; cited in Leung, 2014). Since Singapore and Hong Kong are both the Chinese-majority societies which are strongly influenced by the Confucian tradition and value systems, Tan analyzed the three facets of Confucianism in these three jurisdictions simultaneously from the perspectives of political, philosophical, and popular Confucianism. From the standpoint of CHC, Tan (2018) contended that Singapore,

Shanghai and Hong Kong constitute the EAEM. Specifically, the EAEM is characterized by the following features:

(1) rooted in and shaped by Confucian habitus: unconscious and ingrained worldviews, dispositions, and habits that reflect the standards of appropriateness in a CHC;
(2) aspiration for high performance: a balance between academic excellence and holistic development;
(3) educational harmonization: the art of bringing together different and contradictory means and ends to achieve desired educational outcomes. (p. 118)

Regarding educational harmonization, the three localities achieve this in the following five areas: decentralized centralism, T-shaped curriculum, Teacher-Directed, Student-Engaged (TDSE) approach, learning for assessment, and private tutoring. As these terms have specific meanings in the Asian educational background, I will elaborate on them in sequence. First, decentralized centralism embodies the ostensibly paradoxical tactics that the three jurisdictions utilize to achieve educational harmonization in school management. For instance, the Shanghai educational authority decentralizes the public schools by empowering them with more autonomy. However, the Shanghai authority periodically monitors the school reform and appraisal for the purpose of quality assurance. In this way, the Shanghai educational administration achieves a centralized approach by harmonizing decentralization and centralization. 'T-shaped curriculum' has a vertical and horizontal stroke, wherein the vertical stroke represents the depth of the curriculum (i.e. the foundational knowledge of school disciplines) that is tested in formal assessments. Meanwhile, the horizontal stroke stands for the breath of the curriculum in the form of a comprehensive course of study for students.

The TDSE approach is a hybridized pedagogy that harmonizes traditional didactic-oriented pedagogy and student-centered pedagogy. A case in point is that, in Hong Kong, teachers combine whole-class teaching which focuses on knowledge transmission, with students' self-regulated learning activities, such as group-based work and problem-based learning. Lastly, the EAEM strives to harmonize *Assessment for Learning* (AfL) and *Assessment of Learning* (AoL). According to Tan (2018), AfL refers to 'frequent, interactive assessments of student progress and understanding and understanding to identify learning needs and adjust teaching appropriately' (p. 108). Notable, AfL is a formative assessment that aims to facilitate learners' progress, autonomy, and ownership. On the contrary, AoL is a summative evaluation which is more related to standardized testing, ranking and external accountability. Additionally, Learning for Assessment (LfA), which is the product of AfL and AoL, means 'learning experiences that are planned and carried out for the chief purpose of preparing students for assessment' (p. 109). As noted, AfL is more progressive, flexible, and instrumental for students' learning. AoL narrowly focuses on measurable subject matters.

The last component of the harmonization in the EAEM is the private supplementary tutoring, which is widespread in these three Asian educational systems. Although varying in scope, contents, and purposes, these private supplementary tutorings are also known as shadow education (Bray & Lykins, 2012). Informed by Bourdieu's concept of habitus and capital, Tan (2018) defined the Confucian habitus as 'unconscious and ingrained worldviews, dispositions, and habits that reflect the standards of

appropriateness in a CHC' (p. 57). Further, Tan (2018) observed that the Confucian habitus is evident in Singapore, Shanghai, and Hong Kong in at least three ways: a socio-cultural emphasis on diligence in studying, parental dependence on private tutoring, and public support for terminal exams. Due to the different political, social, economic, and cultural contextual factors, the Confucian habitus works in different ways. However, in light of this collective habitus, many students in Singapore, Shanghai, and Hong Kong attend tutoring classes, which not only provide academic learning, but also enrichment and life-long skills. In this way, the students in these three localities gradually accumulate more cultural capital, which likely enables them to outperform their peers and excel in the future job market.

How does EAEM work?

To better understand the mechanism of EAEM, Tan (2018) investigated how Singapore, Shanghai, and Hong Kong appropriate the Confucian habitus and educational harmonization, with foci on several examples. Typically, Tan analyzed pragmatism in Singapore, correlative thinking in Shanghai, and east–west balance in Hong Kong. In this section, I briefly distill the essence of these three examples.

In the case of Singapore, Tan (2018) acknowledged that the Singaporean educational system is 'tightly coupled' (p. 121), which means that there is a strong coherence between policymaking and implementation. For this reason, Tan utilized the metaphors 'orchestra' and 'kayaking' to illustrate the congruence between policy planning and execution in Singapore. Consequently, pragmatism, as the dominant educational ideology, has penetrated into each layer of education in Singapore and has also extended to political, social, and economic development. Essentially, pragmatism in Singapore manifests the following attributes:

> … opposition to idealism, Utopianism and totalising approaches; adaptive and mimicking nature; [the] focus on finding the technical means for achieving results that often lie beyond public reflection and criticism; and disregard for intangible and unquantifiable values. (p. 123; cited from Tan, 2012, p. 71)

For the sake of pragmatism, Singaporean education strives to achieve certain and concrete results and avoid uncertainty and incompetence.

Following this logic, Tan (2018) observed two noticeable characteristics of pragmatism in education policymaking and enactment in Singapore: preservation of social harmony through policy alignment and strategic adaptation to produce tangible results. In this section, Tan probed into one example of pragmatism in Singapore – critical thinking in Singaporean schools. While teaching critical thinking in schools, Singaporean teachers adopt a collegial and communal, rather than a confrontational and individualistic, stance to foster social cohesion. Regarding teaching critical thinking, Singaporean teachers make good use of the infusion and the discipline-specific approach to balancing the cultivation of critical thinking and guaranteeing the high-test scores for students.

In Shanghai, the major theme of educational reform is correlative thinking, which rejects the 'either-or' and 'cause-and-effect' logics. The emergence of correlative thinking is both a product of historical development and a dialectical tactic to address the educational challenges in the municipality. Tan (2012, 2018) interrogated the tension

between exam-oriented and quality-oriented education in Shanghai, wherein the former connects with a narrow focus on exam techniques, test grades, and college-entrance rate, and the latter endeavors to facilitate students' holistic development through a series of expanded and inquiry-/research-based curricula. Further, exam-oriented education causes several educational problems: heavy schoolwork burden and the school choice fever. To negotiate the tension between these two aforementioned educational paradigms, Shanghai adopts a correlative thinking mindset – 'a convergence of both rather than either the old or the new' (2018; p. 146). Correlative thinking focuses on complementarity and interconnectedness between these two antagonistic educational reforms. On one hand, Shanghai maintains traditional subject-centric approaches and summative tests. On the other hand, Shanghai involves some collaborative, project-based, and inquiry-oriented teaching, which caters to students' individual cognitive and affective needs. They achieved this through three groups of key policy actors: the education authority, school leaders and teachers, and parents.

Jointly influenced by eastern and western culture, the Hong Kong educational system manifests itself through the east–west balance. On one hand, the traditional Chinese culture, especially the Confucian habitus, still exerts a strong influence on the education of Hong Kong. On the other hand, Hong Kong embraced certain pedagogies, such as student-centered and inquiry-based instruction. However, after Hong Kong returned to Chinese sovereignty on 1 July 1997, some political frictions occurred between Hong Kong and the mainland China due to the contrasting political ideologies. To illustrate this point, Tan (2018) identified the controversial Moral and National Education (MNE), which aims to build the national identity and sense of belonging, in Hong Kong. Although it aims to harmonize traditional Eastern/Chinese and modern Western education, the MNE triggers the tensions and dilemmas in Hong Kong. First, Hong Kong and mainland China have divergent perceptions of the approaches to teaching MNE. Some teachers in Hong Kong are cautious about the ideology imposition in MNE. Second, the curriculum aim that instills national attachment and duty in students is potentially contradictory to students' critical thinking and learning autonomy in Hong Kong. This tension contributes to the dilemma of good citizens and critical thinkers.

EAEM, HPES, and the global fourth-way countries: educational utopia or dystopia?

In the previous section, I summarized the conceptualization and defining features of the EAEM. In this section, I analyze the similarities and differences between EAEM, HPES, and the global fourth-way representative countries. To meet this end, I first introduce the concept of the global fourth-way educational movement. Then I tease out the main characteristics of the HPES, and the global fourth-way representative countries.

Hargreaves and Shirley (2012) proposed four types or 'ways' of world-wide educational reforms. The first way of educational change occurred between the late 1960s and the 1970s. Within this reform paradigm, the nation-state invested in public education and teachers enjoyed high professional autonomy in selecting and designing the curriculum. However, teachers received passive trust from parents. The second way of educational change happened after the 1970s (Reagan and Thatcher eras). During this reform period, schools were subject to intensified top-down pressure and teachers received

individualized performance-based pay. The third way of educational change happened in the 1980s (Clinton and Blair eras). There was a participatory professional climate within schools, and teachers experienced renewed professionalism. In the 2000s, there emerged the fourth-way of educational reform, which was characterized by an inclusive and innovative mission, evidence-informed policymaking and sustainable school reform.

Informed by the fourth-way educational reform typology, Finland, Singapore, and Ontario-Canada belong to both the HPES and the global fourth-way countries. Meanwhile, Singapore is also a member of the EAEM. Apart from Singapore, Korea, Japan, and Taiwan can also be loosely considered as the EAEM. After explicating the similarities and differences between the three educational systems, the readers might ask this question, which educational system should be the 'positive reference society'? While the sweeping force of ILSAs is shaping the global education system, comparative educational scholars contend that there are both positive reference societies (utopias) and counter-reference societies (dystopias) created by the different legitimization logics and represented by different media outlets (Sellar & Lingard, 2013; Takayama, 2018; Waldow, 2017). In western social media, Finland has been depicted as a positive reference society characterized by educational equality, teaching excellence, and high school autonomy (Waldow, 2017). Conversely, the EAEM has always been portrayed with the stereotypical images of didactic and text-based teaching, exam-centric environment, and rote-memorizations (Takayama, 2018). The dominant ideology, political system, economic status, and sociocultural backgrounds cumulatively contribute to the formation of the positive or negative reference society.

Based on different understandings of performance, we can also distinguish EAEM, HPES, and the global fourth-way countries. Tan (2018) created the performance matrix that represented four key interpretations of performance: global/local level, and narrow/broad contexts (formal/holistic education) (Figure 1).

From the perspective of this performance matrix, EAEM, HPES, and the global fourth-way countries all perform well in the global and narrow context, such as PISA. However, the global fourth-way countries are adept at the global and broad-oriented educational assessments, such as creativity and critical thinking (Tan, 2019c, 2020). The EAEM countries excel in the local and narrow-oriented educational assessments, such as the high-stakes and summative tests (Tan, 2019c, 2020). Meanwhile, through the lens of the Confucian habitus, the EAEM countries aim to not just produce students who do well in the formal assessments but also develop them to become an exemplary person (junzi) who fulfills a shared vision of human excellence (dao) (Tan, 2018, p. 42). Through this comparative analysis, we can better understand the commonalities and differences between EAEM, HPES, and the global fourth-way countries.

New orientalism or reciprocal learning?

In the arena of the globalized educational policy field, there are two contrasting viewpoints on policy borrowing and referencing: (new) orientalism or reciprocal learning (or two-way borrowing) (Forestier, Adamson, Han, & Morris, 2016; Takayama, 2008). In terms of (new) orientalism, some scholars (see Takayama, 2008; You, 2019) argue that the Anglo-American societies presented HPES, in particular, East Asian countries, as both an inspiration for education reform and a threat to their domestic economy and



Figure 1. A performance matrix. ©Permission needed for reproduction in Charlene Tan *Comparing high-performing education systems: Understanding Singapore, Shanghai, and Hong Kong*, Oxon, Routledge.

global dominance. On one hand, the Anglo-American societies admire or even envy the desirable elements within the East Asian educational system, such as self-perfection, industriousness, and high-respect for educational attainment. On the other hand, the Anglo-American societies portrayed the East Asian educational societies as their rival or even threats to their global competition. In doing so, the educational reformers in the Anglo-American societies legitimatize their educational reform agenda (You, 2019), such as teacher accountability, charter schools, and marketization.

Regarding reciprocal learning, Phillips and Ochs (2003) four-stage educational policy borrowing framework lays the foundation for reciprocal learning. Specifically, these four stages include: (a) the motivation behind cross-national attraction; (b) the decision to borrow; (c) the implementation process; and (d) the internalization and indigenization of change. Within each stage, Phillips and Ochs identified a series of key concepts to illustrate the policy borrowing process, such as externalizing potential, guiding philosophy, and the enabling structures conducive to educational change. Following this academic genealogy, Forestier and Crossley (2015) argue that both-way educational policy and practice borrowing has emerged globally, and a telling example is the Hong Kong-England case. During this two-way borrowing process, Hong Kong's educational reform has sought to implement more progressive, student-centered pedagogies without abandoning its Confucian heritage culture. Simultaneously, England's educational reform agenda prioritized academic rationalism and didactic teaching derived from the Confucian heritage educational model in Hong Kong. As can be seen, borrowing both ways between the East and West facilitates the mobilization of global knowledge, practice, and policy.

In this section, I contend that there is a coexistence of (new) orientalism and reciprocal learning (or two-way borrowing) in the globalized educational policy field.

Traditionally, (new) orientalism ideology, which is usually adopted by Anglo-American societies, dichotomizes, essentializes, and polarizes the distinction between western education and 'other education'. However, as East Asian societies consistently perform well in ILSAs, reciprocal learning, which becomes an emerging mode of educational policy transfer, transcends the limits of the traditional educational policy borrowing/ lending paradigm. To illustrate this point, I identify three representative cases recently occurring in comparative education: (1) the inspiring keynote speech at the Chinese Comparative Education Society Annual Meeting, which was held at the Shaanxi Normal University in China on 26–28 October 2018; (2) the Chinese-Japanese social studies dialogical seminar; (3) the Finnish non-hierarchical, non-affirmative theory disseminated in China. Specifically, reciprocal learning integrates the dichotomies between borrowing/lending, reception/diffusion, and import/export. Second, reciprocal learning reorganizes the 'time' and 'space' elements in policy transfer research. Third, reciprocal learning has the potential to take socio-cultural contexts into consideration. Lastly, reciprocal learning dismantles the dominant Western/Northern discourses in policy transfer, and it is conducive to the 'Asia as method' paradigm in education (Chen, 2010; Zhang, Chan, & Kenway, 2015).

At the Chinese Comparative Education Society Annual Meeting held in Xi'an, Shanxi Province, Professor Minxun Zhang, the so-called 'the Chinese Father of PISA', delivered the keynote speech on Shanghai's world-acclaimed student academic success and teacher effective professional development experiences. The motif of Zhang's presentation was two-fold. First, if China wants to 'tell its educational story well', they have to participate in the global large-scale educational assessment, such as PISA and TALIS. In this way, China might appropriately position its education against the international benchmark. In particular, Chinese educators would better understand their strengths and weakness compared with education in other countries. Second, Chinese educators and researchers have to incisively distill its successful experiences to their international counterparts after the students in Shanghai topped the PISA league table. In this way, Chinese educators can legitimatize their experiences and effectively disseminate them on a global scale. As a corollary, the Ministry of Education in the UK has signed the contractual agreement with the Chinese government. Each year the UK sends about 86 mathematic teachers to Shanghai each year to learn more about the 'mastery teaching method' among the elementary and middle schools in Shanghai.

At a Chinese-Japanese social studies seminar that occurred in Shanghai-China in December 2018, Professor Qiquan Zhong, a renowned curriculum scholar and Japanese educational scholar in China, emphasized that Japanese education researchers have accumulated valuable research experiences, which are inspiring for Chinese education research community. Impressed by the fine-grained empirical classroom instruction research in Japan, Professor Zhong advocated that the Chinese educational scholars should walk out of the office and collect more systematic and detailed evidence in the K-12 classroom. As the chief designer of the New Curriculum Reform in China in 2001, Professor Zhong 'borrowed' many educational ideas from the Japanese educational scholars, such as 'student centeredness', 'constructivism', and 'professional learning community'. All these conceptualizations are embodied in a guideline of the New Curriculum Reform Initiative. Therefore, it can be inferred that Japanese education research has a long-standing impact on Chinese educational reforms.

Prior to this international seminar, the Chair Professor of Educational Leadership at Åbo Akademi University, Michael Uljens, came to Shanghai, China in 2018 to share the 'best practice' of the Finnish education and the non-hierarchical, non-affirmative theory of education that he proposed as one important aspect of foundation for curriculum studies, Didaktik and educational leadership (Uljens & Ylimaki, 2017). First, the serial lectures delivered by Professor Uljens facilitated the transfer of the 'best practice' in the Finnish educational system in China. Second, the non-hierarchical, non-affirmative theory of education developed by Professor Uljens stimulated the mobilization of knowledge at the global scale, especially in China. In this way, there is 'two-way' learning between Finland and China.

The fourth example is the reciprocal learning between Canada and China project, which has been sponsored by the Social Sciences and Humanities Council of Canada (SSHRC) in 2013–2020. There are four Canadian and four Chinese partnership schools joining in this project, which formed the Shanghai and Toronto Sister School Partnership Network (Xu & Connelly, 2017). The Chinese and Canadian scholars adopted the concept of reciprocal learning in this project to foster eastern-western educational partnership (Rigler, 2017; Xu & Connelly, 2017). The main goals of this project encompass: (a) building knowledge and understanding from a cross-cultural perspective; (b) supporting a new approach to research on education in this globalized world; and (c) mobilizing knowledge towards professional, policy-maker, and the general public (Xu & Connelly, 2017). Based on the practice-based methodology, the researchers developed the Reciprocal Learning as Collaborative Partnership (Huang, 2017; Xu & Connelly, 2017).

After briefly sharing these four examples, I would like to discuss how reciprocal learning, as both a novel epistemology and methodology in comparative education research, might work as an emerging educational policy paradigm. Since the inception of the industrial revolution, many Asian countries resort to the western countries for educational policy referencing. For example, South Korea heavily borrowed educational policy and practices from the US. In recent years, due to its stellar high-performing PISA test scores, Shanghai has become a new PISA poster boy since 2009 – an emerging reference society in contemporary international educational policy landscape (Takayama, 2017).

First, reciprocal learning surpasses the limits of the traditional policy borrowing and lending paradigm in comparative educational research (Steiner-Khamsi, 2014; Takayama, Lewis, Gulson, & Hursh, 2017). This present dominant framework in educational policy borrowing and lending created dichotomies between borrowing/lending, reception/diffusion, and import/export (Steiner-Khamsi, 2014). In this increasingly globalized and interconnected society, reciprocal learning entails more interactive and simultaneous educational learning processes. Practically, while students in Shanghai-China, Singapore and Hong Kong perform well in reading, mathematics, and science in the PISA test, they are yet comparatively weak in collaborative problem solving and higher-order thinking abilities. However, the European and North American students and teachers normally excel in the aforementioned aspects. Consequently, Shanghai, Singapore and Hong Kong are both lenders and borrowers simultaneously over the course of the reciprocal learning process. Students and teachers in these representative academic high-performing countries can benefit from reciprocal learning from the different dimensions.

Second, the reciprocal learning process between developed and developing countries enabled me to examine the 'Asia as method' paradigm (Chen, 2010). According to Chen

(2010), the task of Asia as method is to multiply frames of reference in our subjectivity and world-view, so that our anxiety over the West can be diluted, and productive critical work can move forward (Chen, 2010, p. 223). Following Chen's thinking, reciprocal learning can work as an 'imaginary anchoring point' (Chen, 2010, p. 212) and challenge the traditional, widespread, one-sided flow of educational ideas from West/North to East/South. When the West looks East, it will diminish the hegemonic discourse embedded in the educational discourse. Finally, reciprocal learning will enable decolonization in comparative education (Chen, 2010), which might enrich our frame of reference and learning objects among different countries.

Third, reciprocal learning has the potential to take socio-cultural contexts into consideration. In many cases, much international educational policy borrowing falls into the pitfalls of simplistic borrowing and uncritical international transfer, which pays scant attention to the local context (Forestier & Crossley, 2015; Steiner-Khamsi, 2010). Similarly, Tan (2016a) signalled the tensions and challenges when transplanting one set of ideas and practices from one country to another.

What can we really learn from these different educational systems?

In the current field of comparative education, EAEM, HPES, and the global fourth-way countries have caught worldwide attention, therefore, attracting different forms of policy referencing, policy borrowing and even emulation (Elliott, Stankov, Lee, & Beckmann, 2019). Since one major purpose of comparative and international education is to learn some practices and policies from another educational system (Bray, Adamson, & Mason, 2014), it is understandable that we want to learn something beneficial from these different excellent educational systems. In most cases, the underpinning logic associated with these policy-referencing and policy-borrowing practices are:

(a) Country A has a high-performing economy, which is largely the result of the educational system producing workers with the required skills evidenced by international test;
(b) Country B has the opposite features;
(c) If B adopts the critical features of the educational system of A, it will improve both pupil performance and the state of the economy. (Morris, 2015, p. 471)

However, this logic is over-simplistic and does not consider the explicit and implicit contextual factors, such as socio-cultural tradition and cultural script (Forestier & Adamson, 2017). Relating to EAEM, HPES, and the global fourth-way countries, we can see that Finland, as an 'educational utopia', belongs to both the HPES and the exemplar global fourth-way country. The success of the Finnish educational system mainly arises from its high respect for the teaching profession, high-quality teacher workforce, egalitarian and process-oriented learning outcomes, and high school autonomy (Sahlberg, 2014). As a typical Nordic country, the Finnish educational system depends on a series of macro-, meso, and micro- socio-cultural factors. At the macro- level, Finland has a medium-sized population with the well-developed social welfare system. Meanwhile, the Finnish educational system is decentralized and controlled by the municipal-level boards. Overall, the Finish educational structure is less hierarchical and bureaucratic

than the EAEM countries. At the meso-level, the financial and materialistic resources among different Finnish schools are comparatively even. At the micro-level, Finnish teachers have ample professional development opportunities and enjoy a high degree of autonomy (Sahlberg, 2014). In their daily practice, Finnish teachers do not heavily rely on paper-pencil and summative assessment, which is quite different from the EAEM countries.

By contrast, the success of the EAEM mainly come from heavy governmental investment and intervention in education, the socio-cultural values of a utilitarian and technocratic view of education and strong community support for academic success (Tan, 2011). Notably, the widely acclaimed EAEM is maintained by the legacy of CHC and the Confucian habitus to a large degree (Tan, 2016b, 2019d). According to Tan (2018), the EAEM shares three essential similarities, which also contribute to their success: (a) a shared moral vision of education as a public good; (b) an effective use of tactical globalization by the education authority; and (c) Confucian habitus that is not receptive to non-traditional assessments for formal education (p. 172). All these distinctive elements collectively shape the formation of the EAEM.

Due to the aforementioned socio-cultural differences, it is impossible to emulate or transfer one concrete educational policy/practice from one country to another one. For this reason, policy-makers, academics, and practitioners have to acknowledge the 'power of habitus in an educational system' (Tan, 2018, p. 182), which is a major contribution of this book. Regarding the EAEM, we can find that Singapore values pragmatism with the aim of social harmony, policy alignment, strategic adaptation, and tangible academic outcomes. Meanwhile, Shanghai navigates between the exam-oriented quality and quality-oriented education through correlative thinking. Lastly, Hong Kong balances the eastern and western cultural legacies in education. Each locality in the EAEM has its own cultural script. Thus, keeping the cultural narratives in mind, we can possibly avoid the reductionist, truncated, and unwarranted generalization over the course of policy referencing and borrowing. Finally, the socio-cultural view of educational policy analysis challenges the implicit assumptions of the instrumentalist-orientation (Auld & Morris, 2014), which aims to identify and transfer the 'best practices' in an absolute and universal manner. The instrumentalist educational policy borrowing does not consider the implicit socio-cultural backgrounds that shape educational systems, which have an intimate bearing with the purpose, structure, and the evaluation of the system. To remedy this deficit view, the socio-cultural view of educational policy analysis, the main thrust of Tan's book, reminds us of another important dimension in the examination of educational systems and global policy transfer.

In summary, this book has theoretical, practical, and policy ramifications. For educational theory, the book contributes to a nuanced understanding of the EAEM including concepts, features, mechanisms and illustrative examples. Practically, the book sheds light on how to identify CHC and students' learning and assessment for school administrators and other related educational practitioners. At the policy level, the book identified how the national policy is formulated, enacted and evaluated in different educational contexts.

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